

Literacy in Coding (Draft)

The medium chosen for my experience is coding, in which I started learning in senior year of high school. This included learning how to understand basic syntax, seeing the small intricacies of other writers when they code, and learning how to write it myself. This may sound familiar as it is strikingly similar to learning and gaining literacy in a new language. The difference being one's audience may also include a computer's CPU. The CPU in this case handles the logic a person gives it and sends a response back albeit in the form of an error message or a successful compilation.

My first step towards coding literacy was when my AP Computer Science teacher started explaining the way variables are written, and how methods and classes worked. In all honesty I could not understand it at first; it felt completely foreign as Java was already an odd starting point for learning a programming language. This remained until we began studying objects and learning how they work. Seeing how they all connect together as a person might create a class for an object which can hold the variables and methods mentioned above. After that point I understood the knowledge gained intuitively rather than being able to only recite what we were lectured on. That gave me the opportunity to read the logic of a person's code and get more involved with the class. Soon enough I would be watching more videos online on how to read statements and operations in the means of being able to create objects.

After getting past my first step of understanding, the next was trying to read my classmates and other people's code. They all had small differences which could be represented as a writing style in this scenario, which is technically synonymous with its normal usage. It could be the way they placed braces, their naming conventions, comments, and also their logic when performing operations. These were all subtle indicators of how they organized code in a way that made sense to them and how they wanted to present it to others, be it messy or structured orderly. After that the thoughts of 'this seems cool, I want to implement this in my own writing in the future' became more prominent. At this point my literacy in reading code had increased exponentially and made me think more critically about how I understand new subjects.

Eventually I reached the idea ‘I bet I could try to write and implement this idea right now’, which led to installing java and an Integrated Development Environment (IDE) on my laptop at home and writing my own java files. At first, I still struggled with writing classes and objects; then attempting to learn how to effectively use public and private variables and dealing with some of Java’s less appealing syntax when trying to use and implement methods on objects. After those hiccups it became more important that any syntax used would remain legible for others to read, as the first attempt at showing a CS teacher my code led to them struggling with some of the less useful naming conventions chosen. It needed to be ordered, and precise, otherwise an attempt at communication became less convenient and almost arduous to read, just as it is when writing a piece of media and presenting it to others.

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Conclusion area

Go further into what literacy means in context with how I became literate in this subject. It was mentioned earlier in small pieces in reading and writing, however that is not enough.

I’ll be honest, I’m still figuring out what else to mention here. Maybe current day literacy? Or habit building?

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